



THEY'RE LOVIN IT: Mishra (L) and Agarwal at a McDonald's outlet

Fast forward

Once traditional towns are witnessing a slow metamorphosis with their old-fashioned sensibilities increasingly opening up to a more Westernised mindset

■ By Ambresh Mishra

When it comes to attitude, the message on her T-shirt says it all, "OK, I'm perfect. Now stop staring." Pooja Mishra, 25, is a corporate executive in Indore, often scoffed at as a conservative cow-belt town. Cosmopolitanism comes easy to the offspring of new India. With its flourishing textile industry, Indore's old money has always subscribed to old-fashioned sensibilities, but increasingly, its conservative moorings are conversing with a more westernised mindset.

If the scale and grandeur of Ganesha Utsav and Durga Pooja continue to grow every year with the entry tickets costing Rs 325 on an average, the escalating number of malls in the city portray the other side of Indoreans. While the town already has three malls, three more are under construction. An increasing number of its swish set take summer breaks in Europe while making sure that they don't miss

their annual sojourn to holy shrines like Tirupati.

Mishra and her friend as well as namesake, Pooja Agarwal, 24, a call centre employee in Pune, symbolise this synthesis. So Mishra hosts a katha at her home on the weekend, adhering to the custom of fasting on Janmashtami, while thinking nothing of a quick brunch at McDonald's the next morning. The other Pooja balances a gruelling 24-hour work cycle with learning Vedanta at home. Both come from middle-class families. While Mishra's father is a retired public sector official, Agarwal's father owns a bookstore. Both subscribe to the city's largely vegetarian food habits inspired by the Shwetambar Jain-driven philosophy of non-violence. The pretty young things are not just the pin-up girls of globalising India. "We're changing them in turn," says Mishra, pointing at the vegetarian fare on McDonald's happy price menu. "They wouldn't stand a chance of survival here otherwise," she says.

4,000
IS THE AVERAGE
FOOTFALLS IN A
MALL IN INDORE ON
A DAY. IT GOES UP
TO 8,000 DURING
WEEKENDS.